

Guide Your Business Like a CEO

Governance

Book 9



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A stylized illustration of a target with concentric yellow and orange rings. A thick red arrow is shown hitting the bullseye, which is a blue circle. Three white stars are positioned around the bullseye, indicating a successful hit. The background is a solid blue color.

Compensation Plans

Clear pay structures that support performance

Chapter 1

Clear pay structures that support performance. What This Means A compensation plan is how you decide: Who gets paid, how much they get paid, what good performance looks like, and what happens when performance drops. This is not just about money. This is about alignment. A good comp plan makes it obvious: "If I do my job well, I win. If I don't, there are consequences." A bad comp plan creates confusion, resentment, and chaos. Why This Matters:

If pay is unclear, people will optimize for the wrong things.

When compensation is messy: Employees feel underpaid, top performers get frustrated, average performers coast, owners constantly renegotiate pay, and drama replaces accountability. Most owners say:

"People just aren't motivated." No, your comp plan is broken. People do what they're paid to do.

Example: An HVAC Service Business. The business has: 1 owner, 3 technicians, 1 office admin. They do: Repairs, installations, maintenance calls. Revenue depends on: Jobs completed, quality of work, customer satisfaction, speed and reliability. If compensation isn't clear, techs rush jobs, upsell poorly, or disengage. The Golden Rule of Compensation — Beginner CEO rule: Every role needs a clear "win condition." Each person should know: What they are responsible for, how their pay works, what earns more, and what puts their pay at risk. If someone asks, **"How do I make more money here?" You should have a clear answer.**

Compensation by Role (HVAC Example)

1. Technicians.

Bad comp: Flat hourly with no expectations.

Good comp: Base hourly pay plus bonus for jobs completed correctly, positive customer feedback, and upsells done ethically.

This rewards speed and quality, good service, and consistency.

2. Office Admin.

Bad comp: Vague hourly role with no targets.

Good comp: Hourly pay plus bonus for calls answered, appointments booked, and low scheduling errors

This rewards organization, reliability, and revenue support.

3. Owner / CEO. Yes — the owner has a comp plan too.

Bad owner comp: “Whatever’s left,” random draws, guilt-based decisions.

Good owner comp: Fixed salary (even if small) with profit based upside later.

Why this Is Governance (Not HR).

This is not about payroll. This is about how the company is run. Compensation signals what matters, shapes behavior, drives culture, and protects margins. As the CEO, this is your job. If pay is wrong, everything else suffers.

What NOT to Do: Pay everyone the same "to be fair." Change pay rules constantly. Make exceptions quietly. Reward bad behavior. Avoid hard conversations. Let comp live in your head. Inconsistent pay creates distrust faster than anything else.

Final Example: Putting It All Together. The HVAC owner defines comp for each role, explains it clearly, ties pay to performance, and reviews it regularly. Now: Techs know what success looks like, admin supports revenue, owner stops negotiating pay emotionally, and the business feels fair and professional. "Compensation tells people what matters whether you mean it to or not."

“

People don't argue with clear rules. They argue with ambiguity.

Quick Recap: Every role needs a clear comp plan. Pay must align with performance. People do what they're paid to do. Clarity beats generosity. Consistent pay builds trust. Compensation is CEO-level work.

If you want people to act like owners, you must pay them like performers.

To transition to the next chapter, remember: once incentives are clear, the next lever that sustains performance is how people behave daily — culture and standards. We move from pay clarity to behavior clarity to ensure the organization acts with consistency, respect, and momentum across every customer touchpoint.



Culture & Behavior Standards

**What you stand for and how your
team shows it**

Chapter 2

What you stand for and how your team shows it. What this means culture is not perks. It's not slogans. It's not what you say on a wall.

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Culture is how people act when no one is watching.

Behavior standards are the rules that answer:

**How do we treat customers?
How do we treat each other?
What is acceptable? What is not? If you don't define these, your team will make them up.**

Why This Matters: If you don't define culture, your worst behavior will define it for you. Without clear standards: Small problems get ignored, bad attitudes spread, good employees get frustrated, owners get reactive, and drama grows. Most owners say: "We just want good vibes." Vibes are not a strategy. Clear standards protect team morale, customer experience, your time, and your reputation.

Example: A Boutique Fitness Studio. The studio has trainers, front desk staff, and members who show up daily. The experience depends on energy, respect, cleanliness, and communication. One bad attitude at the front desk can ruin the whole brand. Perfect example for culture and behavior standards. What Culture Actually Looks Like (Beginner Level)
Culture shows up in moments like: showing up on time, greeting customers, handling mistakes, talking about teammates, responding under pressure. You don't need values posters. You need clear behavior rules.

Simple Behavior Standards (Fitness Studio Example). Clear standards might look like this: Show up 5 minutes early. Greet every member by name. Phones stay off the front desk. Speak respectfully always. Problems get raised, not gossiped. Mistakes get owned quickly. These are not suggestions. They are expectations. Why Standards Must Be Written.

**If standards live only
in your head:
Enforcement feels
personal, feedback
feels awkward,
corrections feel unfair.**

When standards are written: Feedback is easier, accountability feels fair, conversations are calmer. You're not judging the person. You're pointing to the standard.

How Standards Affect Revenue. Culture affects revenue because customers feel it immediately, retention depends on experience, referrals depend on trust, and reviews reflect consistency. A strong culture keeps customers coming back, keeps good employees longer, reduces chaos, and supports growth. Culture is not "soft." It's operational.

What NOT to Do: Don't avoid setting standards. Don't tolerate "just this once" behavior. Don't enforce standards inconsistently. Don't ignore small issues. Don't confuse kindness with avoidance. What you allow becomes the rule.

Putting It All Together. The fitness studio owner writes clear behavior standards, reviews them during onboarding, reinforces them weekly, and corrects issues early. Now: Staff act consistently, members feel welcomed, drama drops, experience improves, and the brand feels strong. Culture becomes intentional, not accidental.

"Culture is the behavior you allow — not the values you post."

Quick Recap: Culture is behavior, not slogans. Behavior standards must be clear. Written standards make feedback easier. Consistency builds trust. Culture directly impacts revenue. CEO owns culture. If you want a strong business, you must set the tone. As we shift to Chapter 3, understand that strong culture pairs with strong cadence meetings and planning rhythms that keep behavior and priorities aligned week after week.



Team Meetings & Planning

Weekly, monthly, quarterly rhythms that provide focus

Chapter 3

Weekly, monthly, quarterly rhythms that provide focus. What this Means. A planning rhythm is how often your team meets, reviews progress, fixes problems, and plans what's next.

**Meetings are not the goal.
Alignment is the goal. A good
rhythm makes sure everyone knows
priorities, problems don't sit too
long, decisions get made, and the
business keeps moving.**

Without a rhythm, the business runs on chaos and interruptions.

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Why This Matters: If you don't create a rhythm, your business will run on emergencies.

Without regular meetings: Small issues turn into big ones, people work on the wrong things, owners repeat themselves, teams feel lost, strategy never sticks. Most owners say: "We don't have time for meetings." What they really mean is: "We don't have time to slow down enough to get aligned." No rhythm = reactive leadership.

A Growing Digital Marketing Agency. The agency has account managers, designers, and copywriters. Work moves fast. Deadlines pile up. Clients expect updates. Without a rhythm, work slips, miscommunication happens, and clients get frustrated. Perfect example of why planning cadence matters.

The 3 Meeting Rhythm (Beginner CEO Version). You don't need a complicated meeting schedule. You need three types of meetings.

1. Weekly Team Meeting (30–45 minutes).

Purpose: Align the team, surface problems, set weekly priorities.

Simple agenda: What went well last week, what didn't, top priorities this week, any blockers.

For the agency: Review active client work, flag deadlines at risk, reassign work if needed. This keeps the week focused.

2. Monthly Review (60 minutes).

Purpose: Look at results, spot patterns, adjust plans.

Topics: Revenue, client health, team performance, what to improve next month. This is not a status update. It's a reflection meeting.

3. Quarterly Planning (90 minutes).

Purpose: Step back, decide what matters next, set clear goals.

For the agency: Revenue targets, client mix, hiring needs, process fixes. Quarterly planning keeps you from drifting.

Why Rhythm Works (Agency Example).

Before: Constant Slack messages, fire drills, missed deadlines, owner overwhelmed.

After: Weekly clarity, monthly course correction, quarterly direction. Same people. Same work. Better leadership.

What NOT to Do:

Don't meet without an agenda. Don't let meetings ramble. Don't skip meetings when busy. Don't turn meetings into lectures. Don't avoid tough topics. Bad meetings waste time. Good meetings save time.

Putting It All Together. The agency sets a weekly team meeting, monthly review, and quarterly planning. Now: Work is aligned, problems surface early, team feels clear, owner leads instead of reacts. Rhythm creates calm.

"A clear meeting rhythm turns chaos into focus."

Quick Recap: Meetings exist for alignment.

Weekly = execution.

Monthly = reflection.

Quarterly = direction.

Rhythm prevents emergencies. CEO owns the cadence. With cadence in place, the next challenge is people movement ensuring the right people sit in the right seats through promotions, role changes, and exits.

Promotions, Exits & Role Changes

How to move people in and out of
the right seats

Chapter 4



How to move people in and out of the right seats. This chapter is about people movement. That includes promoting someone, changing someone's role, and letting someone go. These moments matter more than almost anything else you do as a CEO. Handled well → the business gets stronger. Handled poorly → culture breaks, trust drops, and problems spread. Governance means you don't avoid these moments. You handle them clearly and fairly.

Keeping the wrong person in the wrong seat hurts everyone. When role changes are avoided, strong employees get frustrated, weak performance becomes "normal," the team loses trust in leadership, and you carry people instead of building leaders. Most owners say:

"They're a good person."

Being a good person is not the same as being in the right role.

Your job is not to save feelings. Your job is to protect the business and the team.

Example: A Home Remodeling Company. The company has a lead carpenter, two helpers, and one project coordinator. As the business grows: One helper wants more responsibility, one carpenter struggles with leadership, and work quality starts slipping. This is a classic moment where role decisions matter.

Promotions: When to Move Someone Up.

A promotion should happen when someone consistently performs well, owns their responsibilities, helps others succeed, and shows good judgment.

Promotion is not a reward for time served. It's a response to proven performance.

Example: A helper consistently runs jobs well, communicates clearly, and solves problems they're ready for more responsibility. Promote based on behavior, not hope.

Role Changes: When Someone Is in the Wrong Seat. Sometimes someone is a great worker, a bad leader, overwhelmed, or misaligned. That doesn't mean they're a failure. It means they're in the wrong role. Example: A lead carpenter is great at hands-on work but struggles managing people and schedules. A role change might mean less leadership, more execution, and clearer expectations. That's not punishment. That's alignment.

Exits: When It's Time to Let Someone Go. Sometimes the answer is exit. Clear signs: Repeated issues, no improvement after feedback, cultural damage, missed standards. Dragging this out hurts you, the team, the customer, and the business. A clean exit is better than a slow decline. Exit should be clear, calm, respectful, and direct. No drama. No surprises.

How to Handle These Moments Well. For promotions, role changes, or exits:

- 1) Be clear about expectations.

- 2) Point to standards, not feelings.

- 3) Explain the decision plainly.

- 4) Set next steps.

- 5) Follow through.

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People don't need everything to go their way. They need things to make sense.

What NOT to Do: Don't avoid decisions. Don't promote out of guilt. Don't keep people "just in case." Don't let poor performance linger. Don't surprise people.

Delayed decisions become cultural poison.

Putting It All Together. The remodeling company promotes the helper who shows leadership, moves the struggling lead carpenter into a better-fit role, and exits someone who won't improve. Now: Roles are clear, performance improves, team morale rises, owner regains confidence. The business gets healthier fast.

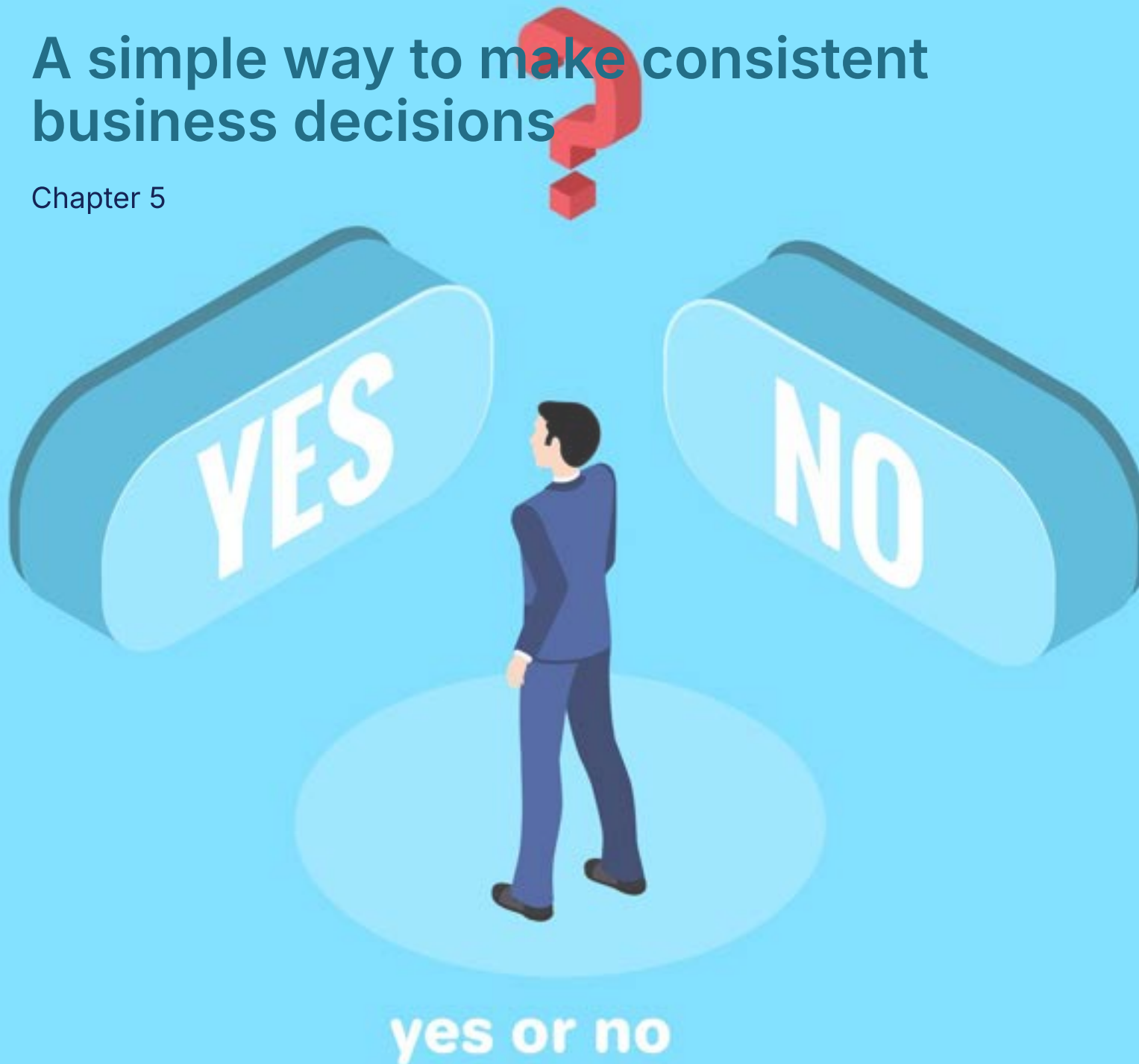
"Right people in the right seats keep the business moving forward."

Quick Recap: Promotions should be earned. Role changes fix misalignment. Exits protect the team. Avoiding decisions hurts culture. Clear standards make decisions easier. CEO owns people movement. Leadership means making hard calls not avoiding them.

CEO Decision Framework

A simple way to make consistent business decisions

Chapter 5



A simple way to make consistent business decisions. What This Means

A CEO decision framework is a simple way to answer this question:

"What should I do next?"

As the business grows, decisions pile up: what to say yes to, what to say no to, what to fix first, what to ignore, what to invest in, what to cut. Without a framework, decisions feel emotional, random, stressful, and inconsistent. A framework turns chaos into clarity.

Why This Matters: Indecision costs more than bad decisions. Most small business owners overthink, delay, second-guess, and change direction constantly. That leads to burnout, confused teams, half-finished ideas, wasted money, and lost momentum. The goal is not perfect decisions. The goal is consistent, repeatable decisions. That's what CEOs do.

Example: A multi-location Auto Detailing Business. The business is growing. Opportunities keep showing up: new services, discounts, equipment upgrades, hiring requests, marketing ideas. The owner feels pulled in ten directions. This is exactly when a decision framework matters. The Simple CEO Decision Framework. Every decision gets run through four questions. If it passes all four, move forward. If it fails one, pause or say no.

Question 1: Does This Help Revenue or Protect It?

Ask: Does this increase revenue? Does this protect existing revenue? Or does it distract? For the detailing business: Adding a premium ceramic coating package, YES. Chasing a random partnership, MAYBE. Redesigning the logo again, NO. Revenue focus keeps decisions grounded.

Question 2: Does This Fit Our Core Offer?

Ask: Is this aligned with what we're known for? Or does it pull us away from our strength? Example: High-end detailing tools, YES. Car audio installation, NO. Growth comes from depth, not distraction.

Question 3: Can the Business Support This Right Now?

Ask: Do we have the time? Do we have the people? Do we have the cash? Do we have the systems? Example: Hiring another detailer when bookings are full, YES. Expanding locations with weak processes, NO. Timing matters more than ideas.

Question 4: Will This Make the Business Simpler or More Complicated?

Ask: Does this reduce chaos? Or does it add moving parts? Example: Standardizing service packages, YES. Adding custom one-off service, NO. Complexity kills scale.

How This Looks in Real Life (Detailing Example).

Decision on the table: "Should we add a new premium detailing package?"

Run it through the framework:

1) Revenue impact? *YES*. 2) Fits core offer? *YES*. 3) Supported right now? *YES*. 4) Simpler or more complex? Still manageable.

Decision: Move forward.

Another decision: "Should we offer mobile tire changes?"

1) Revenue impact? Maybe. 2) Fits core offer? No. 3) Supported? No. 4) Simpler? More complex. Decision: No. No guilt. No debate. No stress.

Why This Is Governance. This framework creates consistency, reduces emotional decisions, protects focus, and helps the team trust leadership. When decisions feel random, teams lose confidence.

When decisions follow a pattern, the business feels stable. That stability is leadership.

What NOT to Do:

Don't decide based on emotion. Don't chase every idea. Don't change direction weekly. Don't say yes to avoid discomfort. Don't confuse busy with progress. Every "yes" costs you something. Choose carefully.

Final Example: Putting It All Together. The auto detailing owner uses the four-question framework, makes faster decisions, says no more often, protects focus, and builds confidence. Now: The team trusts leadership, the business grows cleaner, stress drops, and progress feels intentional. The owner stops reacting and starts leading.

"Great CEOs don't make perfect decisions — they make consistent ones."

Quick Recap: Decisions multiply as you grow. Indecision is expensive. Use four questions for clarity. Revenue, focus, timing, and simplicity matter. Consistent decisions build trust. Governance is leadership in action. You don't need to know everything. You need a way to decide.

Simple Interpretation for Small Business Owners

Books 1–3 teach you how to *get customers*.

Books 4–5 teach you how to *keep customers*.

Books 6–8 teach you how to *run the business behind the scenes*.

Book 9 teaches you how to *lead the business like a CEO*.

PHASE 1 — FOUNDATIONS

What you sell, who you sell it to, and how people find you.

1. PRODUCT (Start Here)

Build something people want → understand problem, customer, offer, landscape, MVP.

Unlocks: Marketing + Sales effectiveness.

2. MARKETING

Now that you know your offer and customer → learn to generate leads.

Unlocks: Sales pipeline consistency.

3. SALES

Once leads are coming in → learn to convert them into revenue.

Unlocks: Customer Success workflows and financial predictability.

Why this phase matters:

You go from *"I have an idea"* → *"I can attract and close paying customers."*

PHASE 2 — DELIVERY SYSTEMS

How you turn customers into raving fans and repeat buyers.

4. CUSTOMER SUCCESS

Once sales convert customers → you learn to onboard, deliver, and retain.

Unlocks: Recurring revenue + testimonials + operational clarity.

5. OPERATIONS

Now you systematize the entire delivery engine: SOPs, checklists, templates, processes.

Unlocks: Quality control, scalability, and reduced chaos.

Why this phase matters:

You go from *"I can sell"* → *"I can consistently deliver and retain."*

PHASE 3 — BUSINESS INFRASTRUCTURE

Tools, numbers, and people who make the machine run.

6. TECHNOLOGY

Once operations are forming → you add the tools that support scale (CRM, website, email, payments).

Unlocks: Data visibility, automation, and speed.

7. HUMAN RESOURCES

Once delivery is predictable → you hire and train people to help.

Unlocks: Delegation, team growth, and freeing the founder.

8. FINANCE

Once business grows → you install financial basics (bank accounts, bookkeeping, cash flow, budget, taxes).

Unlocks: Correct pricing, healthy margins, and sustainable growth.

Why this phase matters:

You go from *"I do everything manually"* → *"My business has real systems and support."*

PHASE 4 — SCALING THE BUSINESS

You become the CEO instead of the operator.

9. GOVERNANCE

Once you have customers, systems, tools, finances, and a team → you implement the rhythms and standards that keep the business aligned.

Includes:

- Comp plans
- Cultural standards
- Planning rhythms
- Promotions/exits
- Decision-making framework

Unlocks:

- True leadership
- Predictable growth
- A business that runs without you

Why this phase matters:

You go from *"I built a business"* → *"I operate like a CEO."*

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